



GRANTS

AND CORPORATE FUNDING

WHAT IS AVAILABLE? AND IS IT WORTH THE EFFORT?

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All shluchim agree that the relationship between a shliach and his baalebatim is the cornerstone of a Chabad House; their financial support makes them a part of the Chabad House and they give the shliach spending autonomy. Nevertheless, as donors continue to cut back during these times of recession, some shluchim have obtained unexpected funding from business grants and corporate donations.

Some have focused on local businesses that have an interest in investing in their own communities. “We support local, and local supports us,” says Rabbi Yosef Eisenbach, shliach to Litchfield, Connecticut. Showing loyalty as a customer is good way to help create this relationship. By way of example, Eisenbach suggests buying kosher wine from local liquor stores over bringing cases from New York. Though the markup on the bottles may be slightly more, by becoming a consistent and loyal customer, store owners will more than pay their way down the line in donations and partnerships.

Stores might, at times, offer to substitute services,

goods, and services over actual money grants. Products with shorter shelf-lives, such as fresh fruit, for example, can be used by the shliach and help the store with its turnover rate.

Many national chains also look to invest in their local communities. Besides nationwide grants, local branch managers have autonomy in building relationships with local nonprofits. Programs like Walmart's Local Community Contribution offer microgrants beginning at \$250 to local nonprofit organizations. Approach the managers of local chains, and ask them what programs they offer.

When approaching a business as a potential donor, shluchim advise going directly to the president, skipping any marketing or media heads. The owner obviously has the greatest discretion when it comes to investing in the community, and by forging a relationship, it allows for a much deeper level of future commitment.

After a relationship between the shliach and his new partner has been created, it's important to keep it up. Reinvest even a small percentage of the money by sending reminders and gifts for birthdays and holidays.

Another key to successfully approaching potential sponsors for various events throughout the year is to use strategic timing regarding requests so that they will most benefit the potential investor.

"There's a season for every industry," Eisenbach says. For example, during the fall, when people are preparing for the winter and their heating needs, approach a local oil company. During the spring, a store that specializes in cooling or central air conditioning is on the lookout for new customers for the coming summer months.

While big grants from major corporations and Facebook competitions have helped some shluchim, they are not consistently available to everyone. Large federal government grants are also difficult to come by and might require extensive lobbying. Some shluchim and askonim have invested time and funds in these lobbying efforts, but they might not always be practical for everyone. What is more, legislation is making it more difficult for these earmarks to be

passed and the funds to be distributed.

Some shluchim, however, have taken advantage of monies available on the county and state levels for their programs. Rabbi Shmuel Fuss, shliach to Riverside, CA, runs Project PRIDE, a drug-prevention education and awareness program. He was able to apply for a small grant from county offices under their Assets Forfeiture fund, a fund that gives donations towards drug education from money confiscated during drugs busts. Like similar funds, it's important that your programing match the goals of the fund. Thus, while your Tanya shiur

might not be the right cause, humanitarian causes like working with soldiers, drug rehab, or CTeen could be the perfect fit for a similar grant.

In the end, it doesn't matter if you are soliciting a grant from a corporation or asking a baal habayis for a donation. Either way, community members are directly engaged, which builds relationships with everyone involved and automatically draws them into Yiddishkeit, whether they donate or not. This is part of the beauty and innovation of shlichus, the ideal way set in place by the Rebbe, himself. 

APPROACHING NONPROFITS

Numerous nonprofit organizations, both Jewish and secular, offer grants that shluchim can take advantage of. Below are tips from a senior leader of a global philanthropic organization.

ASK FOR ADVICE. When you approach a nonprofit, their assumption will be that you're after money. However, as the saying goes, "If you want advice, ask for money; if you want money, ask for advice." Instead of directly asking for funds, ask for advice. Let them know about the project you're working on; ask about connections they can make for you and for specific feedback. This creates an opportunity for dialogue and builds a relationship with the nonprofit.

BRING CREDIBLE BACKING. If you are contacting the nonprofit or potential donor on the basis of someone else's recommendation, don't just name-drop. The credibility of other funders is essential. When other donors think highly of you and are willing to personally vouch for you, it speaks volumes.

BACKUP YOUR APPEAL. Stay away from a purely emotional appeal. Playing

to sympathies is good, but the ingenuity of your solution goes even further. How the money will be spent affects how it will be given. Identify a problem and propose your solution with a way to measure your achievements. Donors are thinking more strategically about how they can maximize their investments, especially in light of the great number and diversity of investments out there. Make methodical choices and proposals so that your pitch stands out. Nonprofits want their philanthropic work to go further, so try to show them the reach of their money. Matching grants are very attractive for this reason.

BE UPFRONT ABOUT WHO YOU ARE. Many people have assumptions and preconceptions about Chabad. Nonprofits are no exception. Be open and forthright in your communication, acknowledge their

hesitations, and explain your goals. This declaration will give you a lot of credibility. By clearing the burden of assumptions from the potential donor, you're able to immediately address what you have in common: your shared passion and vision for a Jewish future.

GIVE IT TIME. It's rare that you'll get what you are looking for on a first call. Ask for advice (as mentioned above), and get to work. Be upfront with the donor after your initial meeting that you're going to look for funds now based on his advice. Ask if you can call back if you need further advice. Research, look around for donations, and follow up with the nonprofit. By doing this, you'll build an advisory relationship, and the funds will follow. The sink-or-swim model of shluchim drives ingenuity and innovation, and nonprofits are aware of and impressed by this fact.